ABSTRACT OF THE DISCLOSURE

A system and method for detecting and actively countering covert surveillance in retail or public environments. The surveillance method involves utilizing mobile devices (e.g., smartphones with deep hardware integration) as nodes in a mesh network to interrogate short-range radiofrequency (e.g., NFC) enabled covert listening devices ("bugs") or data collection points, and simultaneously employing integrated cameras to capture visual data (e.g., facial recognition, shopping basket contents). The present invention provides a countermeasure system comprising a detection module, a threat analysis module, and a neutralization module. The detection module identifies the presence and activity of such covert surveillance devices and mesh network communications. The threat analysis module assesses the nature and intent of the detected surveillance. The neutralization module then employs various techniques, including targeted signal jamming, data obfuscation, or localized regulatory enforcement, to disrupt or mitigate the surveillance. A regulatory framework is proposed as an inherent countermeasure, granting a perpetual, no-fee license to all governmental entities for the use of the countermeasure technology.